

An Autistic Student You Support at University

For disability-support workers, mentors, note-takers & PAs — supporting an autistic student (roughly ages 18–25).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a student's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." University is a *massive* transition, and many autistic students **hit a wall** — burnout, anxiety or crisis — in their first or second year. As a support worker or mentor you can be the steady, predictable relationship that keeps them afloat: clear communication, protected focus, and early flagging when the load is tipping into burnout.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Stops attending, replying or self-care	Autistic burnout from cumulative university load
Wants everything by email; avoids calls/meetings	Single-channel communication reduces the load
Misses deadlines, can't start tasks	Autistic inertia + executive overload, not laziness
Goes quiet or withdraws for days	Shutdown/recovery under overwhelm
First identified only now, in crisis	A common late-identification point

Try this

- **Be the predictable relationship** — same time, same person, same format; confirm in writing.
- **Communicate in writing**, literally, one task at a time; help break tasks into steps.
- **Protect focus and interest** — structure study around their tunnels, not constant switching.
- **Normalise reduced load** — an extension, deferral or interruption is a legitimate recovery step.
- **Know the signposts** — disability service, wellbeing, mentoring, autistic student communities — and go *with* them.
- **Check in literally** when they go quiet; burnout needs reduced load, not a pep talk.

Avoid this

- Surprise changes, pressure to "push through," or generic social-skills advice.
- Equating silence or a missed session with "not engaged."
- Making decisions *for* them — support autonomy and choice.

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout** (exhaustion, loss of skills, reduced tolerance) and signs of crisis — escalate to the wellbeing/disability team and, where needed, safeguarding. A temporary reduction in load is an evidence-aligned recovery step, not failure.

If the student is a woman

Late-identified women mask intensely; a “sociable high-achiever” may be privately collapsing. Take reduced tolerance and withdrawal seriously, however together they look.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.4), the **Family guide** (Part 4) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Raymaker et al. (2020); Knight (2021, *tunnels not tasks*); Pearson & Rose (2021). Full citations are in the source drafts.